



Democracy or accuracy?

Many years ago I was often accused of in some sense opposing the internet. Clearly, I had not done a good job in expressing myself, and so I had better be more careful now.

My objections had always been directed at the nonsense that would come from so many of the self-styled internet evangelists; one of the funniest that caught my attention a few years ago was a prediction by no less a person than MIT's Nicholas Negraponte that within a couple of years there would be more Barbie dolls attached to the internet than Americans. I have no idea what they put in the water at MIT, but if criticising such nonsense makes me an internet opponent, then so be it.

A century and a half ago, people made similarly exaggerated claims for the telegraph. (Yes, I mean the morse code electric telegraph.) According to one author on the subject, because the invention of the telegraph had such a profound effect, "experts" extrapolated and decided that the telegraph would "eliminate the drudgery of manual work and create a world of abundance and peace." The book from which I am quoting is "The Victorian Internet" by Tom Standage — I often suggest that people read this in order to help put into perspective some of the wild expectations about the internet.

The silliest notion is also one of the most attractive to many people, and that is the general idea of the democratic internet. Now, the word "democratic" is a political term, and there are many aspects of the internet — uses to which it can be put — where politics has no place at all. I am mainly thinking of the internet as an information resource. A democratic internet implies that anybody can put up anything they like, regardless of accuracy.

One example: I travel to Kathmandu quite often, and know the city well. A few years ago I wanted to use Google Earth to explain to a friend how to find a rather obscure bookshop. Useless. Most of the landmarks — hotels, restaurants, shops, etc. — had been wrongly marked. In particular, one chap had marked dozens of places, all of them a few hundred metres away from their actual locations — he had clearly not set his GPS device properly. As an information resource, this made it totally useless.

I have written before here of the unreliability of some of the information on Wikipedia, in particular controversial subjects where zealots have taken over and allow no opposing views to their own — these are clear examples of politics inter-

fering in information; the modern equivalent of book burning.

Well, things are starting to change, but not far or fast enough, in my opinion. These changes have been prompted by malicious edits to Wiki pages that implied that US senators Robert Byrd and Edward Kennedy had died. The suggestion is that any changes to a page will be checked before actually being added to the site. However, in a recent interview, the founder of Wikipedia, Jimmy Wales, made it clear that this rule — already applied on the German site — would only apply to pages concerning living people.

How about the rest of the information that is up there? A golden rule in editorial offices is that several pairs of eyes need to check every single item that is to be published. That rule is intended to eliminate factual errors, but it also helps prevent malicious mis-information of the sort that occurs on Wikipedia.

In the interview, Wales stated that "what we are looking for right now is the exact parameters of how we would implement in a way that would get very strong support... instead of a complicated hierarchical system... somebody who has been around the community for a while will check it."

He seemed very defensive — meeting much opposition from "the community", no doubt.

This is one very small step in the right direction, but it might end up giving more strength to the zealots — who by definition have dug themselves deeply into "the community" in order to press their own agendas forward.

The information aspects of the internet such as Wikipedia and Google Earth need much stronger and more careful management. It is a form of publishing, after all, and the editorial checks and balances that have been developed over many decades in the print industry have not become redundant simply because of the addition of a new medium. The accessibility of this new medium actually makes them all the more important and necessary today.



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